Water Care

THE WATER CHALLENGE · TRACK A2 · CHALLENGE PACK V2.0

Challenge Guide: Building a prospecting tool a small charity can run

How to use this pack to design a grant-prospecting solution that works on real Canadian funders, fits a two-person fundraising team, and can be handed to the client after the event.

2026-10-19
As-of date

4 layers
Organization · Market · Operations · Evaluation

> **Read this first.** Water Care is a fictional organization created for the AI Hackathon 2026. Its strategy, finances, people, funders and history are invented and are **not** WaterAid Canada's. The public sources and peer charities in Layer 2 are real. Never attach invented facts to a real funder, and do not publish the fictional material as fact.

What is in the pack

Four layers, one for each thing a working solution needs. Water Care stands in for the client so you can build safely, then swap in real data.

1 Organization

Who are we matching for?

- Profile and 36-field eligibility passport
- Swap template for the client's real data
- Assumption register: questions for your mentor
- Fit rubric, capacity and cost model
- Pipeline history, relationships

2 Funding market

Where do opportunities come from?

- **Real** public source register with access rules
- **Real** peer-tracing method using CRA gift data
- Fictional funder registry and network
- Source snapshots for change detection

3 Operating model

How does a 2-person team use it?

- Weekly routine, about 2 staff hours
- Briefing-note template + worked example
- Decision log and reason codes
- Risk controls; staff feedback history

4 Evaluation & economics

Does it work, and is it worth it?

- 25 test cases with worked answers
- Ranking scenario: 8 options, 45 hours
- Success metrics
- Running-cost model

FILES

File	Use it for
Water_Care_Challenge_Guide.pdf	This guide: how the pieces fit and what good looks like
Water_Care_Organizational_Profile.pdf	Readable profile, passport and decision rules
Water_Care_Challenge_Workbook.xlsx	All data and live models; tabs colour-coded by layer; start at 00_START_HERE
data/ (CSV + JSON)	The same data, ready to load into your tool
schemas/ (JSON Schema)	Shared formats for funder, opportunity, recommendation and decision records
templates/briefing_note.md	The one-page brief, ready to fill

REAL OR FICTIONAL?

REAL Source register (L2_Source_Register), peer charities (L2_Peer_Tracing), Canadian charity rules, the brief.

FICTIONAL Water Care, every funder F001-F056, every person R01-R12, every .example URL, all history and numbers.

SUGGESTED PATH FOR A TEAM

1. Read the profile PDF and the passport. Agree your scope with your mentor using L1_Assumptions.
2. Build the pipeline: monitor, extract, screen gates, score, brief (L3_Workflow steps 1-5) using the shared schemas.
3. Run it on L4_Test_Cases and L4_Ranking_Scenario; compare against the worked answers.
4. Point it at real public sources (Layer 2) and show a few real, verified results.
5. Present the routine, the controls and the running cost: that is what makes it adoptable.

What a strong solution looks like

The brief's three tiers, translated into what you can show with this pack. Aim for every team to reach Strong; Exceptional is about judgment, not volume.

Tier	What the brief asks	Show this	Where in the pack
Baseline	Finds relevant public opportunities; accurate, linked summaries	Extracted opportunities in the shared format; every field quoted and dated; no invented facts	schemas/opportunity; L4_Test_Cases O02, O04, O06, O10
Strong	Explains rankings; separates eligibility from strategic fit; flags missing information	Hard gates first, citing passport IDs; weighted fit second; 'Uncertain' routed to REVIEW; conflicts and stale sources flagged	L1_Fit_Rubric; O03, O11, O12, O13, O18, O21
Exceptional	Pre-empts opportunities from past timelines and strategy shifts; helps staff say no	Finds programs before calls open (annual reports, snapshots); uses relationships with consent; respects capacity; recommends declining with reasons	O08, O15, O19, O24; L4_Ranking_Scenario; L2_Source_Snapshots

DESIGN PRINCIPLES THE CLIENT CARES ABOUT

- **Humans decide.** The tool screens, ranks and drafts; fundraisers accept or reject, and every rejection teaches it something (L3_Decision_Log).
- **Evidence or nothing.** No deadline, amount or eligibility rule without a quote, a source and a date. 'Unknown' is a valid answer.
- **Fewer, better.** Two fundraisers can review about five briefs a week. Ten good declines are worth more than forty maybes.
- **Swap, don't rebuild.** Read the organization's facts from data (passport, rubric weights, capacity), never from code or prompts.
- **Cheap to run.** AI cost is small; people and maintenance are the real cost (L4_Running_Cost). Design for low maintenance.

COMMON WAYS SOLUTIONS FAIL

Failure	Why it matters	Test case
Keyword matching instead of eligibility checking	Recommends local-only or Indigenous-led-only funders	O02, O10, O20
Treating an out-of-date page as current	Applies to closed or changed programs	O03, O13
Picking one date when sources disagree	Misses the real deadline	O11
Ignoring capacity	Recommends work the team cannot do well	O19, O24, ranking scenario
Reading only the first source	Misses tobacco holdings, strategy pivots, hidden programs	O08, O13, O22
Using relationships without consent	Damages board trust	O22 (R03)

Build it so the client can swap in its own data

Water Care is a stand-in. A tool that reads the organization from data, not from code, can be handed over by replacing a few files.

WHAT GETS SWAPPED

- **Eligibility passport**: 36 fields. L1_Swap_Template marks each *Public* (in public records) or *Internal* (only the client knows), with the owner role who confirms it.
- **Fit weights and thresholds**: L1_Fit_Rubric yellow cells.
- **Capacity and cost**: hours, rates, committed work (L1_Capacity_Model).
- **History**: past applications, relationships, feedback. These stay inside the client's systems.

WHAT DOES NOT CHANGE

- The workflow and controls
- The shared data formats
- The source register and peer-tracing method
- The test cases (they become regression tests)

> **Test of a good design:** could the client replace Water Care's passport, weights and capacity with its own in under an hour, without touching code?

HIGH-PRIORITY QUESTIONS FOR YOUR MENTOR (FROM L1_ASSUMPTIONS)

ID	Assumption in the pack	Ask your mentor
A01	2 institutional fundraisers; 25% and 55% of time on new business	How many hours a week do your fundraisers really have for new prospects after stewardship and reporting?
A02	Proposal effort: LOI 8 hrs, short application 24, full proposal 60, government call 220	How long do each of your application types actually take, including program-team input?
A03	Minimum viable grant $15,000	What is the smallest grant worth pursuing for a cold funder? For a warm one?
A04	Weekly review of up to 5 briefs, about 60-90 minutes	How many recommendations can your team realistically review each week?
A05	Fit weights: strategy 25%, economics 20%, geography 15%, relationship 15%, win signals 10%, timeline 10%, strategic value 5%	Which factors matter most when you decide? Would you change these weights?
A06	Gift acceptance: tobacco, weapons, gambling excluded; extractives and beverage companies need CEO review	What does your gift acceptance policy exclude or send for review?
A07	Country list: 4 priority, 2 secondary	Which countries can WaterAid Canada currently fund, and which are priorities for new money?
A08	Current funders are in the pipeline history	Can we get a list of current and lapsed funders (names only) to exclude or route to stewardship?
A16	No donor personal data goes to external AI services	What is your policy on using AI tools with donor or board information?
A17	Monthly running budget for the tool (see L4_Running_Cost)	What monthly cost is acceptable, and who owns the tool after the hackathon?

Real sources, and how to find who funds work like this

Everything here is public. Verify each link; respect site terms; no paid databases or logins without the client's permission.

ID	Source	What it tells you	Access rule
S01	**CRA List of Charities (charity search)**	Registration status, designation (foundation vs. charity), T3010 financial summary, and the list of qualified donees each charity gave to, with amounts	Public, free
S02	**T3010 charity returns open data (Government of Canada)**	Bulk charity return data for all Canadian charities	Public, free (open licence)
S03	**SEAL Lab, McMaster: cleaned T3010 data incl. gifts to qualified donees (T1236), 2003 to current**	Cleaned, joined history of charity returns and gifts	Free; registration required (respect terms)
S04	**Government of Canada grants and contributions (proactive disclosure)**	Federal grants and contributions by recipient, program, amount	Public, free
S05	**Global Affairs Canada Project Browser**	Canadian international assistance projects, partners, countries	Public, free
S06	**IATI d-portal (International Aid Transparency Initiative)**	Published aid activities by funders and implementers	Public, free
S07	**Funder websites: grant guidelines and call pages**	Current priorities, eligibility, deadlines, amounts	Public pages only; respect robots.txt and terms
S08	**Funder annual reports and financial statements (PDF)**	Strategy changes, new envelopes, grantee lists, investment holdings	Public
S09	**Funder news releases and leadership announcements**	CEO changes, strategy pivots, new programs	Public
S10	**Corporate sustainability / ESG and community-investment reports**	Corporate giving priorities, operating locations	Public
S11	**Philanthropic Foundations Canada (member directory)**	Directory of Canadian grantmaking foundations	Public pages only
S12	**Community Foundations of Canada (directory)**	Local community foundations	Public
S13	**Imagine Canada Grant Connect**	Commercial foundation database	PAID: off limits unless the organization already subscribes and permits use
S14	**LinkedIn and other login-only sites**	People and relationship data	OFF LIMITS: login and terms restrictions

PEER TRACING: THE STRONGEST PUBLIC SIGNAL

A Canadian charity's annual return lists the registered charities it gave to, with amounts. Foundations that already fund international water, health or gender charities are the most likely to fund a similar one. This is real, free data.

1. List peers (L2_Peer_Tracing) and find each one's charity record.
2. Search foundations' gifts to qualified donees (S01, S03) for gifts to those peers.
3. Rank foundations by how many peers they fund, how much, and how recently.
4. Remove the organization's existing funders (route to stewardship using its own records).
5. Run the rest through the hard gates, then the fit rubric.

Peers listed: Ryan's Well Foundation, CAWST (Centre for Affordable Water and Sanitation Technology), Engineers Without Borders Canada, HealthBridge Foundation of Canada, Plan International Canada, CARE Canada, Aga Khan Foundation Canada. Summaries are for orientation; verify each.

PRACTISE SAFELY FIRST

- **L2_Funder_Registry**: 56 fictional funders as Water Care's records hold them. Some records are out of date on purpose: the sources are the truth.
- **L2_Source_Snapshots**: the same pages at different dates. Detect what changed and whether it alters eligibility (geography change, hidden program, conflicting deadline, stale page).
- **L2_Funder_Network**: shared trustees and co-funding links for the network-mapping stretch goal.

SOURCE-UPDATE PLAN (A BRIEF DELIVERABLE)

For each source type, state how often you check it, how you detect change (content hash or diff), and how stale is too stale. A sensible default: call pages weekly, annual reports on publication, CRA data annually, anything older than 90 days flagged.

The weekly routine

Steps 1-5 run automatically. Steps 6-7 are human decisions (dark). About two staff hours a week in total.

STEP 1
Monitor sources
Weekly (Mon, automated)
Tool

STEP 2
Extract opportunities
Weekly (automated)
Tool

STEP 3
Screen hard gates
Weekly (automated)
Tool

STEP 4
Score and rank
Weekly (automated)
Tool

STEP 5
Draft briefing notes
Weekly (automated)
Tool

STEP 6
Fundraiser review
Weekly (Tue, 60-90 min)
Foundations Officer

STEP 7
Pursuit decision
Fortnightly (30 min)
Director, Philanthropy

STEP 8
Log decisions
Weekly (automated + 5 min)
Tool + Officer

STEP 9
Hand off to CRM
On pursue
Foundations Officer

STEP 10
Quarterly calibration
Quarterly (2 hrs)
Director + Officer

CONTROLS

Risk	Control	Owner
Invented facts (deadline, amount, rule)	Every extracted field must quote its source and date; null when absent; tests O03, O12 check this	Tool + Officer
Misread eligibility	Gates cite passport IDs; Uncertain routes to REVIEW; tests O02, O06, O10, O20	Tool + Officer
Stale information	Freshness rule: flag sources older than 90 days; change detection on snapshots	Tool
Gift-acceptance breach	Excluded sectors decline; review sectors always go to the CEO	Director / CEO
Misuse of relationships	Never suggest an approach through a person with consent = No	Tool + Director
Donor personal data exposure	Relationship and donor data stay in the organization's own systems; only public funder data goes to external AI services unless approved	Director
Over-recommending	Hard cap: max 5 briefs/week; capacity check before PURSUE	Tool
Model or prompt drift	Rerun acceptance tests quarterly and after any change; target 90%+ pass	Director
Running cost creep	Monthly cost cap and report (L4_Running_Cost)	Director
Automation bias	Briefs show confidence and unknowns; sample-check 1 declined item per week	Officer

The one-page brief

What a fundraiser reads. Every fact carries its source and date; inferred dates are labelled as inferred.

Section	Must contain	Worked example: O08 Ostrander
Header	Funder, opportunity title, recommendation (PURSUE / QUEUE / CULTIVATE / REVIEW / MONITOR / DECLINE), fit score, confidence (High/Medium/Low)	Ostrander Foundation: Global Health Systems envelope (LOI). Recommendation: PURSUE. Fit 4.0. Confidence: Medium (program not yet on funder website).
Why it fits	Up to 3 bullets, each tied to a rubric criterion (C1-C7) and a theme or country code	C1: WASH in healthcare facilities is named in the envelope (WASH-HCF, core). C2: sub-Saharan Africa includes Malawi, Mozambique, Ethiopia. C7: multi-year grants of $150k-$600k.
Eligibility check	Table: gate, result (Pass/Fail/Uncertain), evidence quote, source URL, retrieved date	G1 Pass: 'registered Canadian charities' (annual report p.14, retrieved 2026-10-11). G2 Pass: sub-Saharan Africa. G3 Pass: health systems incl. WASH. G4-G8 Pass. Note: grants page (retrieved 2026-10-11) does not list this program.
Key dates	Each date with status: Confirmed (quote + source) or Inferred (never presented as fact)	LOI window Nov 1 - Dec 12, 2026: Confirmed (annual report p.14). Full-proposal date: unknown.
Money and effort	Grant range, likely ask, application type, fundraising + program hours, expected value, fits remaining hours?	Likely ask $375k over 3 years. LOI 8 hrs now; if invited, full proposal ~60 hrs + 20 program hrs in Q4. Expected value about $110k (30% chance of award x $375k, less expected effort). Fits remaining Q3 hours: Yes.
Relationship path	People with a link (consent = Yes only), strength, suggested ask of them	R09 (board director) met Ostrander's CEO in 2025; strength 1; consent Yes. Ask: a short note to the CEO when the LOI goes in.
Risks and unknowns	What could make this wrong; what to confirm with the funder	Program absent from website: confirm with Ostrander that LOIs are open. No grant history in international health.
Next step	One action, owner, due date	Officer emails Ostrander to confirm the LOI window by Oct 30; LOI drafted by Nov 20.
Sources	Every source used, with retrieved date	ostranderfdn.example/reports/annual-2025.pdf (2026-10-11); ostranderfdn.example/grants (2026-10-11)

DECISION LOG: THE LEARNING LOOP

Every brief gets a human decision. Disagreements need a reason code: ELIG (eligibility error), DATE (deadline or date wrong), STALE (source out of date), FIT (fit misjudged), ECON (not worth the effort / economics), CAP (no capacity this period), REL (relationship context the tool lacked), GIFT (gift-acceptance issue), DUP (duplicate or existing funder). Over time these show where the tool is weak (for example, many DATE codes mean extraction needs work) and justify changing weights.

Does it work, and is it worth it?

TEST CASES AND WORKED ANSWERS

25 opportunities (L4_Test_Cases) cover the difficulties real prospecting hits: local-only funders, revenue caps, stale pages, conflicting dates, hidden programs, strategy pivots, gift-acceptance conflicts, capacity limits, and ambiguous eligibility. L4_Expected_Behaviour gives the answer and the reasoning for each. After the event they become the client's regression tests: rerun them whenever the model, prompts or rubric change.

RANKING SCENARIO: 8 ELIGIBLE OPTIONS, 45 HOURS

Rank	Decision	Why
K2	PURSUE	Highest fit (about 4.5) and strong value for only 8 hours now; core theme, priority country, warm relationship. LOI costs 8 hrs now; the full proposal falls in Q4.
K1	PURSUE	Core theme (WASH-HCF) in a priority country; fit about 3.8; 24 hrs fits the remaining capacity.
K3	MONITOR + ask funder	Strong fit (about 4.1) and the best expected value per hour but 60 fundraising + 20 program hrs by Dec 10 cannot fit 45 hrs. Ask Tidewell about the next round; do not start a proposal you cannot finish well.
K6	QUEUE to Q4	Moderate fit (about 3.0) on a core theme; LOI is cheap and due Jan 30. Use spare hours now or schedule for January.

Hours: K2 (8) + K1 (24) = 32 of 45; the remaining 13 can take K6's LOI early. The point is the trade-off: K3 is a better fit than K1 but cannot be done well in time. Defensible alternatives exist; teams should show their reasoning.

SUCCESS METRICS

Metric	Definition	Target
Recommendation acceptance rate	Share of briefs fundraisers accept (PURSUE/QUEUE/CULTIVATE)	Above 50% by month 3
Eligibility error rate	Share of tool 'eligible' calls later found ineligible	Below 5%
Fabrication rate	Any date, amount or rule with no source quote	Zero
Acceptance-test pass rate	Share of L4 tests where tool decision matches expected	90% or higher
Staff hours saved	Prospect-research hours before vs. after	At least 4 hrs/week
Qualified opportunities per quarter	New PURSUE decisions that reach submission	4 or more
Cost per qualified opportunity	Monthly running cost x 3 / M6	Below $500
Win rate on tool-sourced applications	Won / (won + lost)	At or above historical rate
Time to brief	Days from source change to brief	7 days or less

RUNNING COST (ILLUSTRATIVE; L4_RUNNING_COST)

~$30	~$810	~$1,400	0.1
AI usage / month	Total / month incl. people	Manual research it replaces / month	Extra grants / year to break even

AI prices in the model are placeholders: update them with current published pricing. The lesson holds anyway: review time and maintenance, not AI usage, drive the cost. Design for low maintenance and short reviews.

SHARED DATA FORMATS (SCHEMAS/)

Schema	Holds	Key rule
funder	A grantmaker, aliases, restrictions, peer gifts	Every restriction maps to a passport field
opportunity	One fundable opportunity	Every value has a source quote and date, or is null; conflicts listed
recommendation	Gates, scores, decision, confidence, next step	Gate results cite passport IDs; consent = Yes for relationship paths
decision	The human outcome	Reason code required when the reviewer disagrees

SUBMISSION CHECKLIST

- ☐ Working demo on public funding information (plus the test cases)
- ☐ Explicit fit criteria and a ranked list with source-linked briefs
- ☐ Staff feedback method, source-update plan, and operating costs
- ☐ Which assumptions you validated with your mentor, and which remain open
- ☐ Results on L4_Test_Cases and the ranking scenario, including what your tool got wrong
- ☐ How the client would swap in its own data